

NOLWAZI HLOPHE

Senior Specialist: Fintech | Financial Sector Conduct Authority, South Africa

+27 83 578 1026 | nolwazihlophe@gmail.com | linkedin.com/in/nolwazi-hlophe | nolwazihlophe.github.io

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Fintech policy specialist with 10+ years of experience spanning central banking, financial regulation, and emerging-technology research across Southern Africa and international forums. Currently leading regulatory initiatives on artificial intelligence, open finance, decentralised finance, and suptech at the FSCA. Recognised international contributor through the IAIS Fintech Forum, the IFWG Regulatory Guidance Unit, and the Cambridge Centre for Alternative Finance. Track record of translating complex technology developments into actionable regulatory frameworks, building cross-border partnerships, and advancing digital financial inclusion.

CORE COMPETENCIES

- Fintech Policy & Regulation
- Regulatory Sandbox Management
- AI Governance & Supervision
- DeFi & Crypto-Asset Frameworks
- Open Finance & Data Sharing
- Suptech & RegTech
- Stakeholder Engagement
- Research & Policy Drafting
- Team Leadership & Mentoring

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Specialist: Fintech | FSCA South Africa

May 2023 – Present

- Lead research and regulatory policy development across AI, open finance, DeFi, suptech, and insurtech, translating emerging-technology developments into conduct-authority frameworks.
- Co-lead the Regulatory Guidance Unit of the Intergovernmental Fintech Working Group (IFWG); develop operational strategy, resolve queries from financial innovators, and report to member regulators.
- Serve as Deputy Chairperson of the IFWG Open Finance Integration Working Group, driving South Africa's open-finance regulatory agenda.
- Manage live cases within the IFWG Regulatory Sandbox, assessing innovation applications against consumer-protection and systemic-risk criteria.
- Contribute to three workstreams of the IAIS Fintech Forum (AI supervision, structural-impact monitoring, suptech), co-authoring the Application Paper on the Supervision of AI.
- Spearhead the development of an MOU between the FSCA and the Information Regulator on data governance, privacy, and responsible adoption of emerging financial technologies.
- Lead and mentor a specialist fintech team, supporting professional growth, leadership development, and delivery against divisional KPIs.

Deputy Director: Financial Regulation & Supervision | Digital Frontiers

Dec 2020 – Apr 2023

- Managed the Digital Financial Inclusion Supervision (DFIS), Instant & Inclusive Payment Systems (IIPS), and Certified Digital Economy Program (CDEP) capacity-building programmes – supported by the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation – exceeding programme KPIs.
- Cultivated strategic partnerships with the SADC Banking Association and SADC Secretariat, driving member-institution participation in regional digital-finance capacity-building initiatives.
- Led and mentored staff, setting performance targets and supporting leadership development.
- Convened workshops on CBDC design, big-data analytics, and green finance for regulators and industry stakeholders.

- Delivered bespoke training workshops for NCC, MTN Eswatini FinCo, and internal teams on cybersecurity and privacy.

Non-Executive Director of the Board | Mukuru Financial Services Eswatini *Jan 2023 – Feb 2023*

- Provided independent oversight on compliance-risk management and strategic direction; attended quarterly board meetings and managed key stakeholder relationships.

Regulatory Program Lead | Digital Frontiers *Apr 2020 – Dec 2020*

- Designed and delivered regulatory-focused course content for financial supervisors and policymakers.
- Co-convened Digital Identity Week 2020, a flagship multi-day virtual event on identity regulation and digital public infrastructure.

Senior Research Analyst | Cenfri *Jan 2019 – Mar 2020*

- Conducted applied research on financial inclusion, digital payments, and regulatory innovation; authored research reports, policy briefs, and client proposals.
- Managed project timelines, stakeholder engagement, and contracting for multi-country research engagements.

Project Manager: CBE Intelligence Hub – Fintech Unit | Central Bank of Eswatini *May 2018 – Dec 2018*

- Established and managed the central bank's inaugural Fintech Unit, defining its strategic mandate and operational framework.

Macroprudential Analyst | Financial Stability Unit | Central Bank of Eswatini *Nov 2017 – Dec 2018*

- Conducted macroprudential analysis of investment managers, SACCOs, and household debt to inform financial-stability policy.
- Drafted the national financial inclusion and systemic-risk frameworks aligned with SADC standards.
- Developed Eswatini's Financial Inclusion Index using the World Bank's diagnostic toolkit.

Graduate Trainee | Financial Stability Unit | Central Bank of Eswatini *Nov 2015 – Oct 2017*

- Supported macroprudential surveillance, financial-stability conference delivery, and Global Money Week awareness campaigns.

Learning Facilitator | 2U *Jun 2022 – Present*

- Prepare and lead live virtual class sessions for first- and second-year university Economics courses.

EDUCATION

MPhil Financial Technology – University of Cape Town	2025 – 2026
MCom Economics – University of Pretoria	2014 – 2016
BCom (Hons) Economics – University of Pretoria	2013
BCom Econometrics – University of Pretoria	2008 – 2012

Additional Certifications:

- CCBE – Project Management for Non-Project Managers (GIBS, 2018)
- Digital Identity Certificate & Anti-Money Laundering Compliance Certificate (2020)
- Cybersecurity Certification (Programming Hub)
- Machine Learning Certification (Programming Hub)
- Implementing the NIST Privacy Framework (LinkedIn Learning)

INTERNATIONAL & ADVISORY ROLES

- Faculty Member & Council Member (Women's Regulatory Network), Cambridge Centre for Alternative Finance, Cambridge Judge Business School – AI in Financial Services for Public Authorities Programme (Mar 2026 – Present)
- Advisory Council Member, RegTech Africa Conference (Dec 2021 – May 2025)
- Guest Lecturer, University of Cape Town – “Blockchain and Digital Money: The Future of Money” online course, covering financial inclusion, crypto assets, and CBDCs in emerging markets (Jul 2020)
- Mentor, Juliana Imam Intellectual Property and Creative Consult (JIIPCC) Legal Mentorship Programme – topics: IP, patent drafting, AI, fintech, blockchain (Nov 2022)
- Panel Speaker, ID4Africa LiveCast Season 4 – “Mobile ID in Advanced Economies” (Feb – Apr 2022)

RECOGNITION

- Listed among 60 African Women Experts in Fintech – Africa Shapers (2022)
- Certificate of Appreciation, ID4Africa League of Champions – for contribution to knowledge sharing and capacity building (2022)

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Programming: Python, R, Solidity, SQL/MySQL | **Data & ML:** Machine Learning, Database Management | **Tools:** Git, GitHub

PUBLICATIONS & PORTFOLIO

nolwazihlophe.github.io